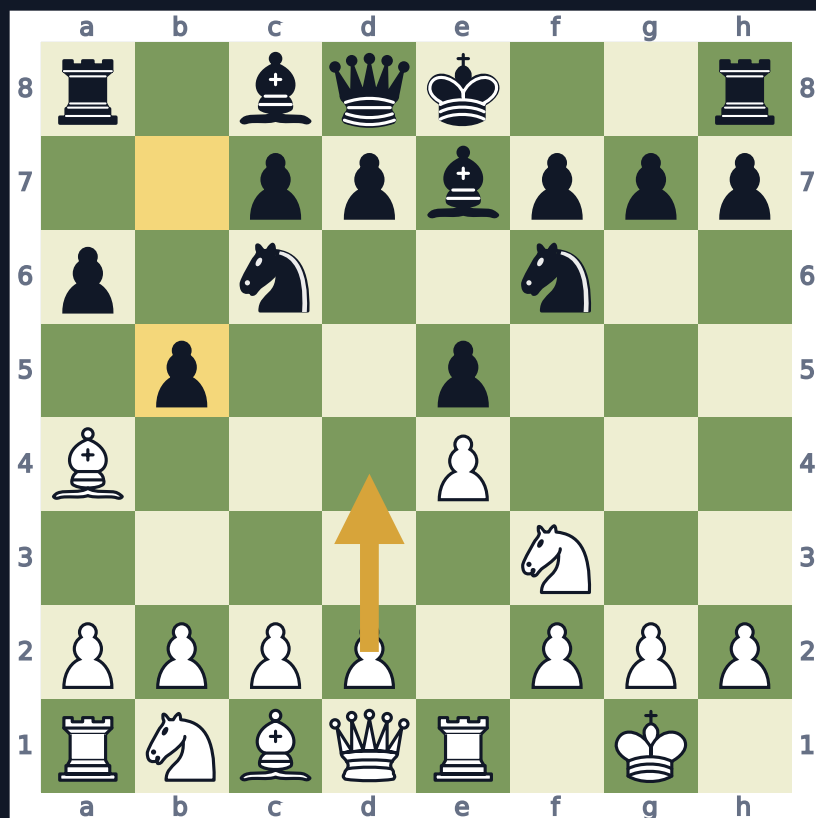


03

Map of the Ruy Lopez Families

Closed, Berlin, and Open Spanish: three different ways Black answers the pressure on e5.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will recognize the major families by structural choice and know what each side is trying to prove.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 013 | PAGE 4

Decode: Closed Spanish family

Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

LESSON 014 | PAGE 8

Play: Closed Spanish family

Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

LESSON 015 | PAGE 12

Decode: Berlin family

The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

LESSON 016 | PAGE 16

Play: Berlin family

The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

LESSON 017 | PAGE 20

Decode: Open Spanish family

In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

LESSON 018 | PAGE 24

Play: Open Spanish family

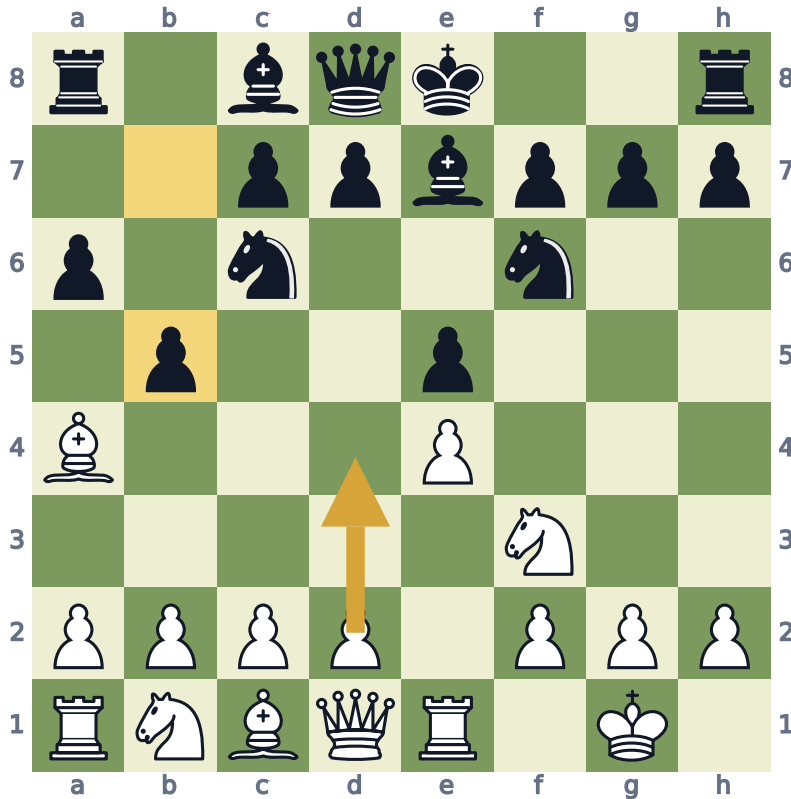
In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will recognize the major families by structural choice and know what each side is trying to prove.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Closed Spanish family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

DECISION RULE

Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Reroute pieces, prepare ...d5, and create queenside or kingside activity according to White's setup.

WHITE'S RESOURCES

White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position.

MEMORY RULE | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Reroute pieces, prepare ...d5, and create queenside or kingside activity according to White's setup.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position.

FAILURE MODE

Calling a retreat passive without seeing the square and break it prepares.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

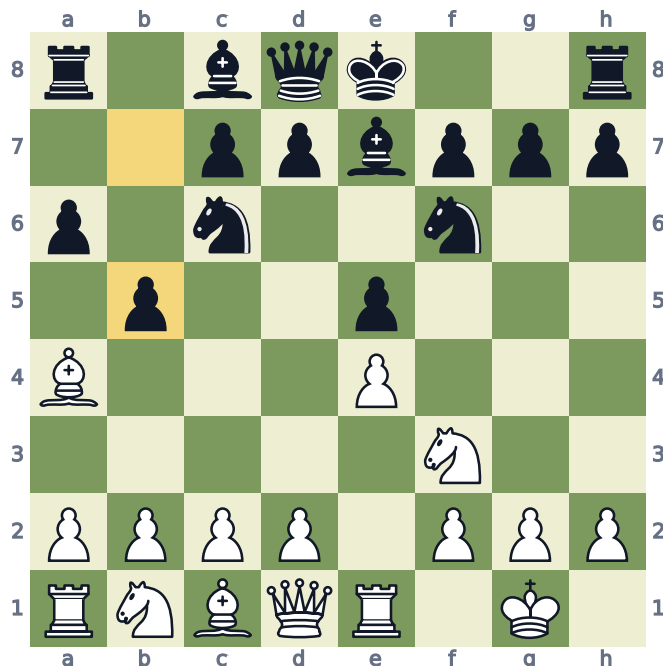
RULE | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job? White's resource is: White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position. The line fails as a template when: Calling a retreat passive without seeing the square and break it prepares.

STORE THIS | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

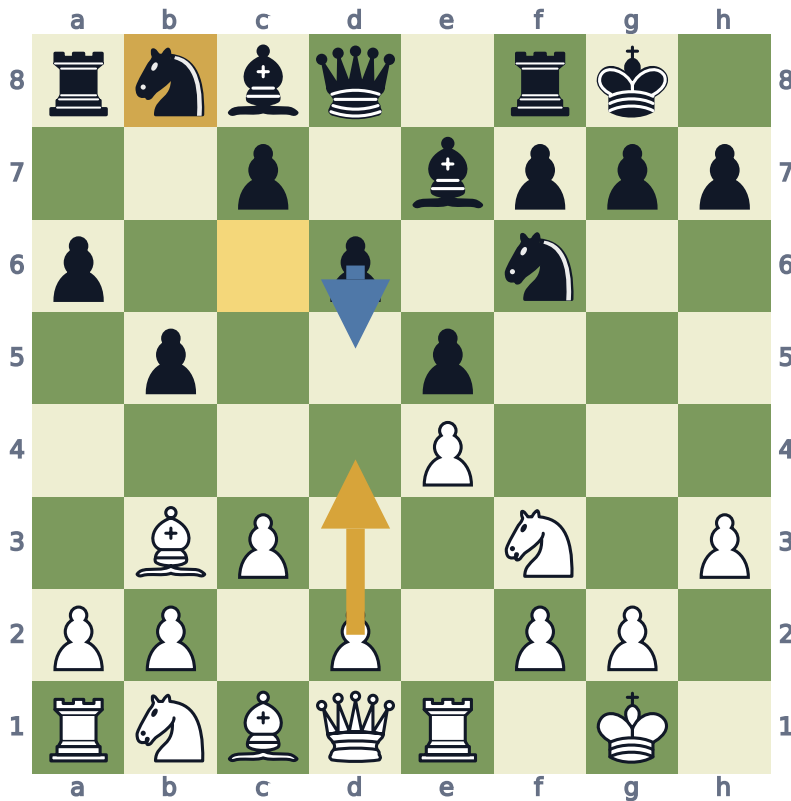
1. Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center. 2. Reroute pieces, prepare ...d5, and create queenside or kingside activity according to White's setup. 3. White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position. 4. Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job? 5. Calling a retreat passive without seeing the square and break it prepares.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Closed Spanish family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

DECISION RULE

Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Reroute pieces, prepare ...d5, and create queenside or kingside activity according to White's setup.

WHITE'S RESOURCES

White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position.

MEMORY RULE | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Reroute pieces, prepare ...d5, and create queenside or kingside activity according to White's setup.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position.

FAILURE MODE

Calling a retreat passive without seeing the square and break it prepares.

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Ask: Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

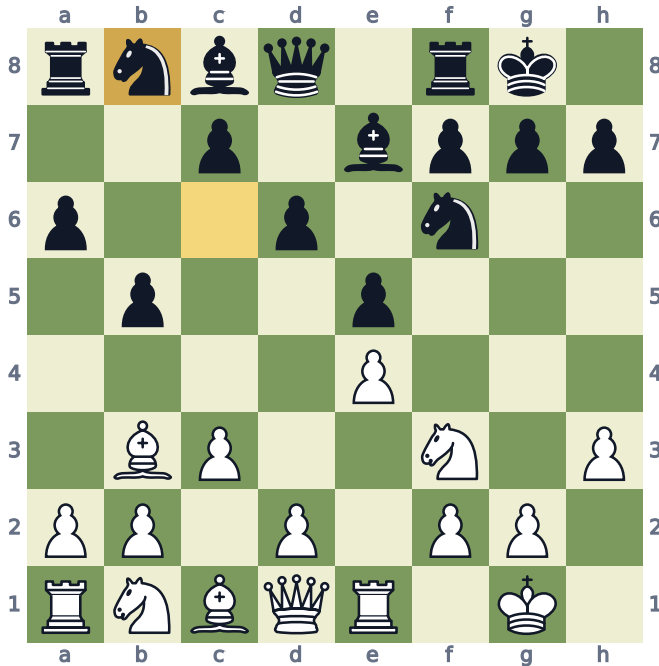
RULE | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8



- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Nb8: Black reroutes a knight to b8; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black maintains e5 and retreats the c6 knight to reorganize, accepting space pressure in exchange for a resilient center.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job? White's resource is: White completes c3-d4 and improves knights before opening the position. The line fails as a template when: Calling a retreat passive without seeing the square and break it prepares.

STORE THIS | Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

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ANSWER KEY

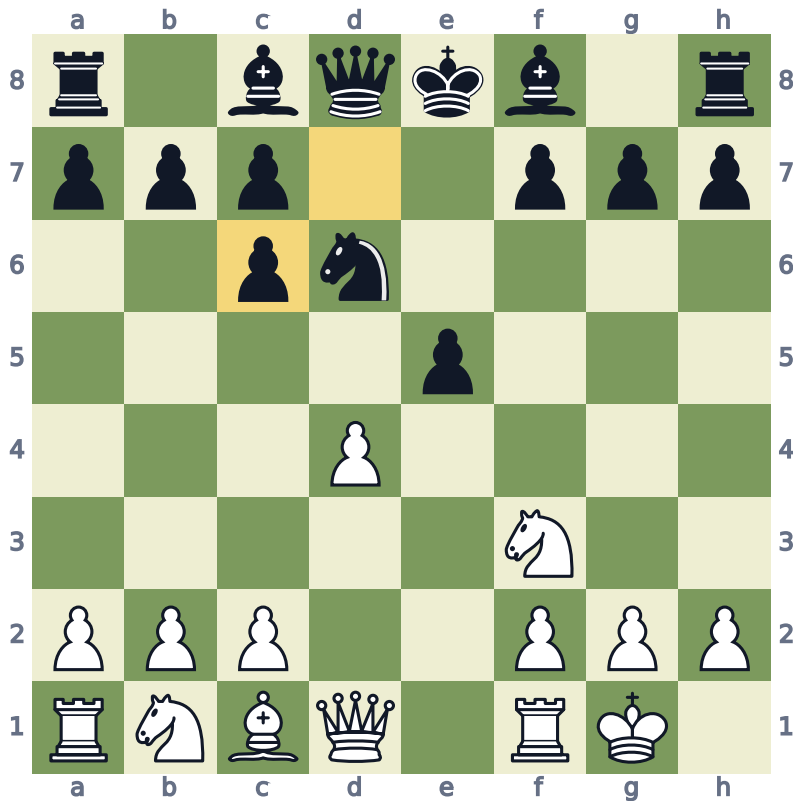
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Berlin family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame.

DECISION RULE

Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Activate the king and bishops, solve the rook connection, and pressure White's advanced e-pawn.

WHITE'S RESOURCES

White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken.

MEMORY RULE | The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

The plan map

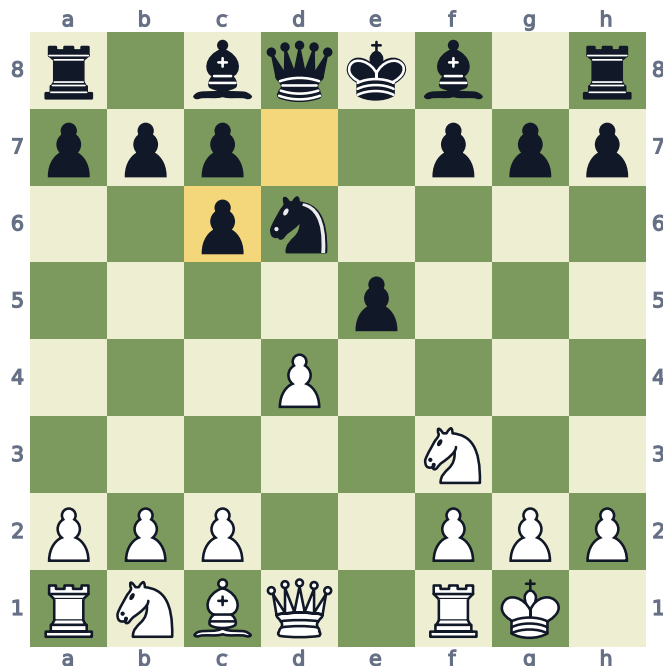


INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Nd6: Black reroutes a knight to d6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bxc6: White releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxc6: Black releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay? White's resource is: White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken. The line fails as a template when: Assuming queenless means easy; one passive move can let White fix every weakness.

STORE THIS | The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

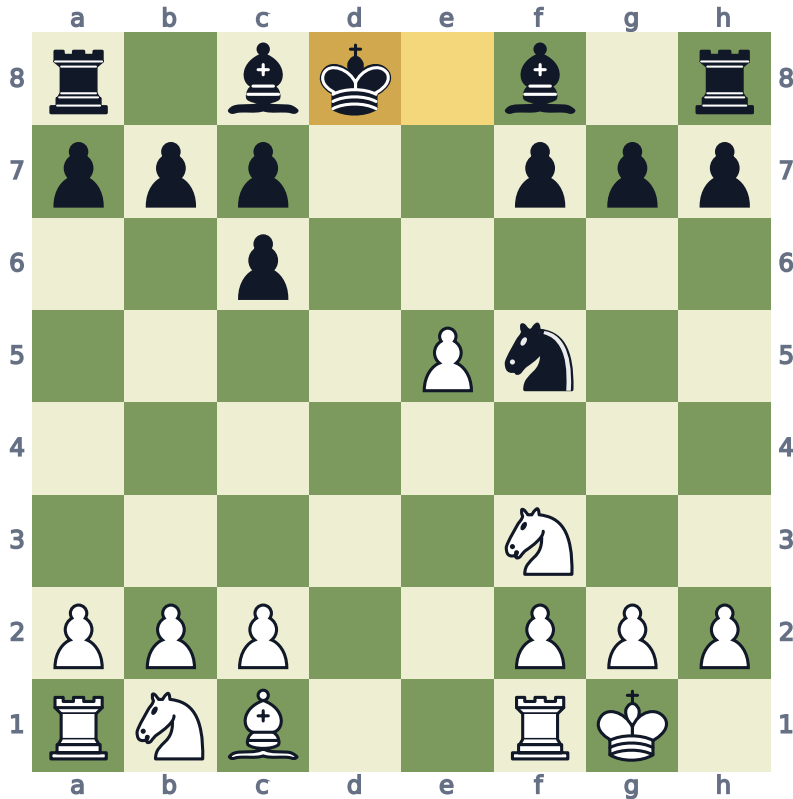
1. The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame. 2. Activate the king and bishops, solve the rook connection, and pressure White's advanced e-pawn. 3. White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken. 4. Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay? 5. Assuming queenless means easy; one passive move can let White fix every weakness.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Berlin family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame.

DECISION RULE

Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Activate the king and bishops, solve the rook connection, and pressure White's advanced e-pawn.

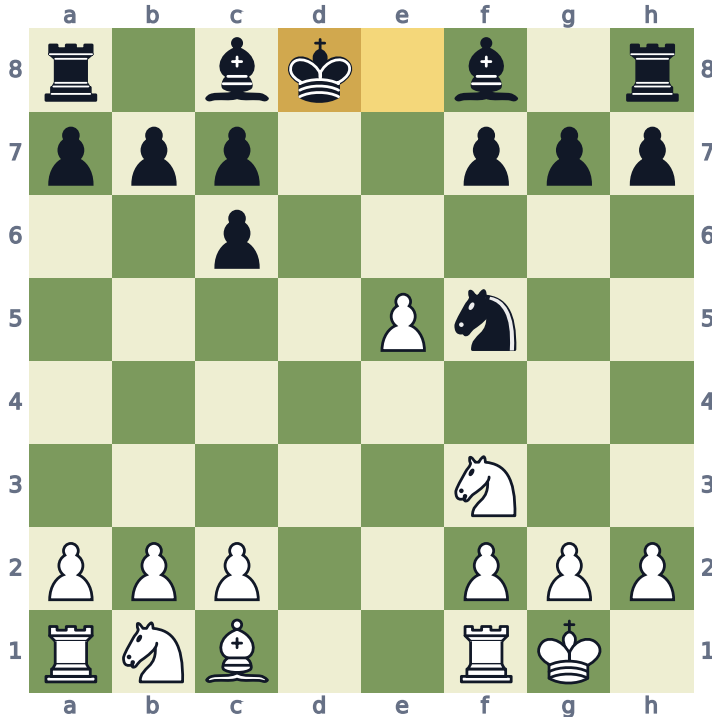
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken.

MEMORY RULE | The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame.

BLACK'S PLAN

Activate the king and bishops, solve the rook connection, and pressure White's advanced e-pawn.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming queenless means easy; one passive move can let White fix every weakness.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

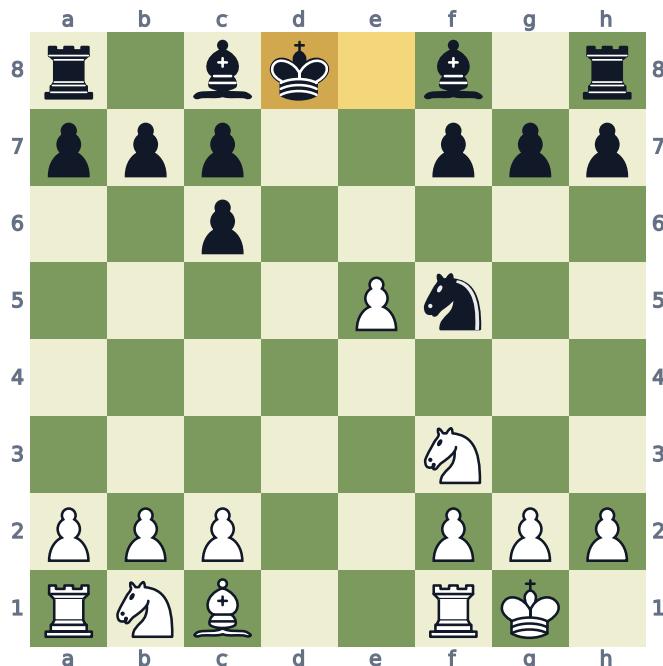
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8



- Bxc6: White releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxc6: Black releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf5: Black reroutes a knight to f5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Qxd8+: White releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Kxd8: Black releases tension by capturing on d8; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Berlin trades castling rights for queenless solidity, bishop activity, and a famous structural endgame.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay? White's resource is: White uses the safer structure, space, and queenside majority to restrict Black before the bishops awaken. The line fails as a template when: Assuming queenless means easy; one passive move can let White fix every weakness.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

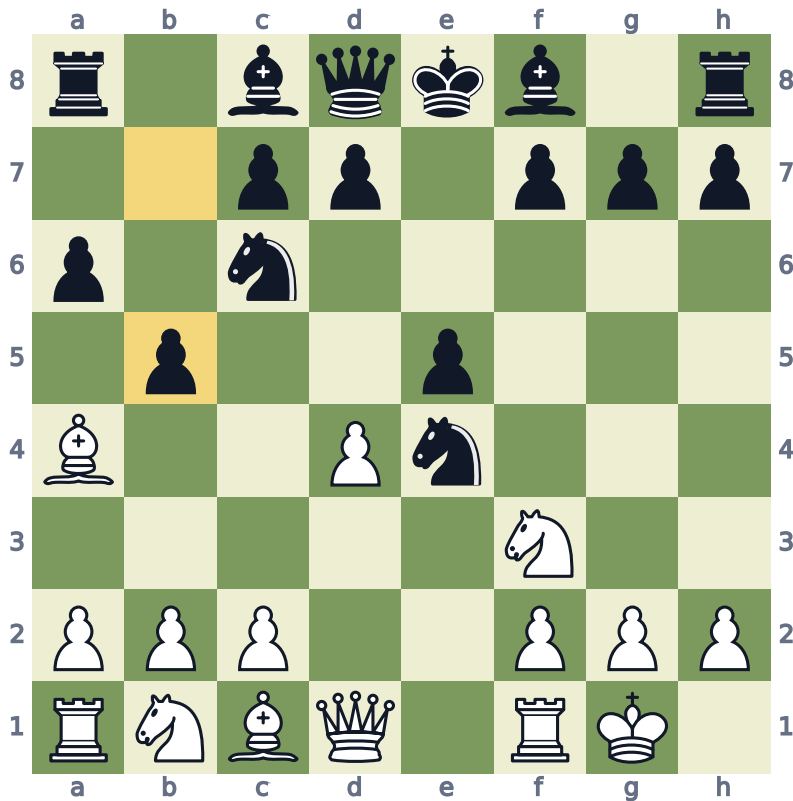
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Open Spanish family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

DECISION RULE

Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic.

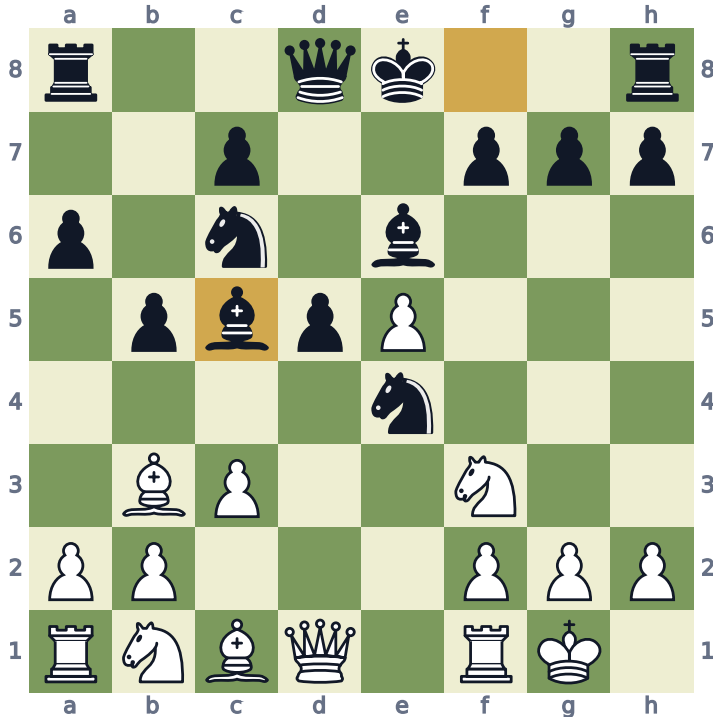
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates.

MEMORY RULE | In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



WHITE'S PLAN

White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates.

CUE

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

FAILURE MODE

Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

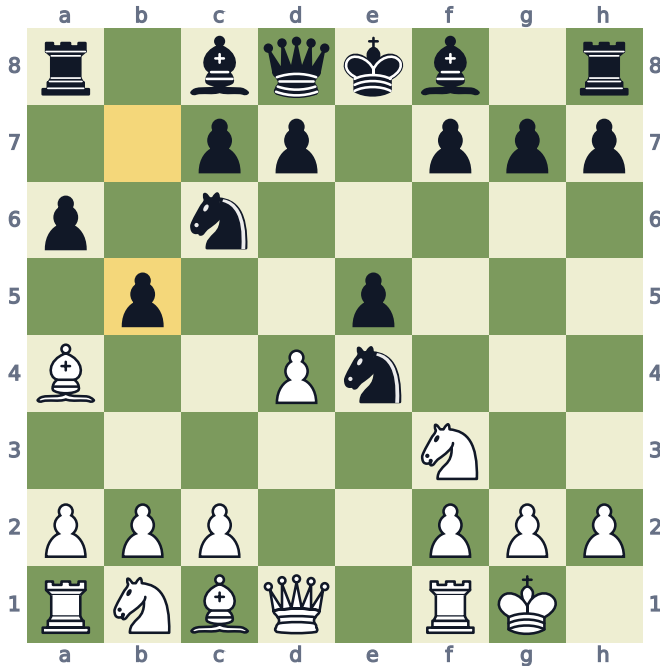
RULE | In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? White's resource is: White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates. The line fails as a template when: Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

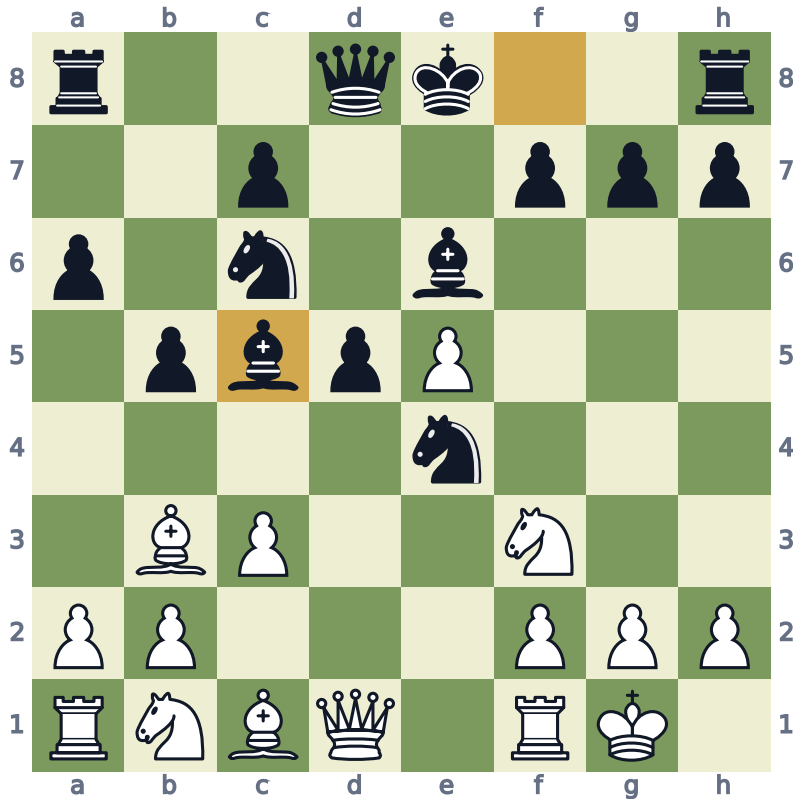
1. Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight. 2. Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic. 3. White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates. 4. Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? 5. Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Open Spanish family



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

DECISION RULE

Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic.

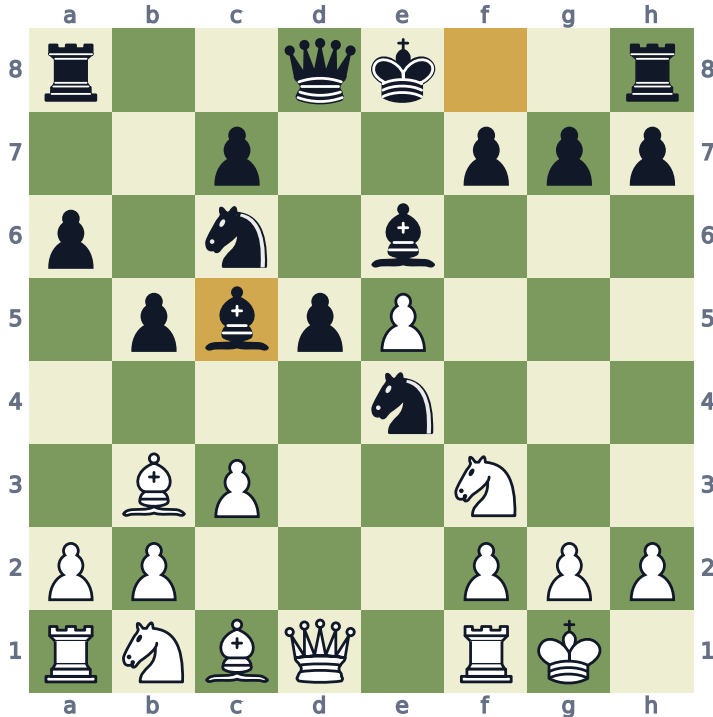
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates.

MEMORY RULE | In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates.

FAILURE MODE

Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

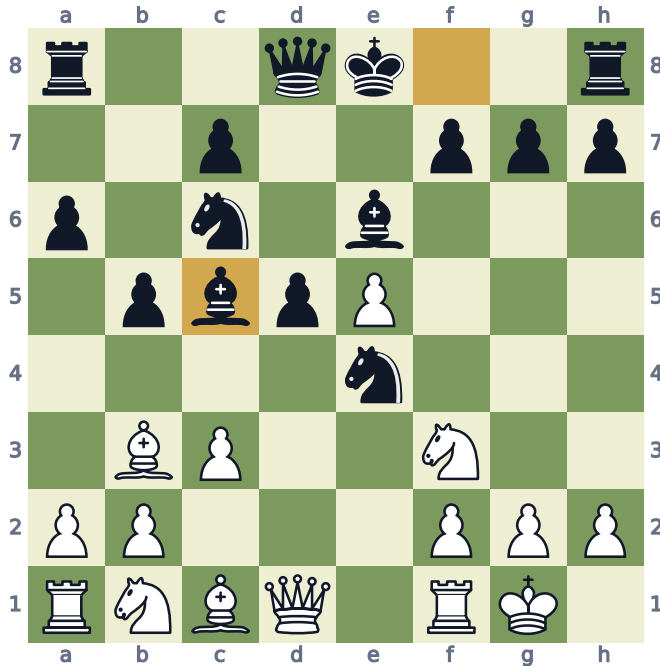
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5



- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d5: Black challenges the center or offers dynamic activity, depending on the system.
- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- Bc5: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? White's resource is: White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates. The line fails as a template when: Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

STORE THIS | In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Black takes e4 and builds a broad active center; White receives targets and tactical pressure against the centralized knight. 2. Use development and central space, support the e4 knight, and calculate every d5 or f7 tactic. 3. White attacks the center with c3, Nbd2, and tactical pins before Black consolidates. 4. Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move? 5. Believing central activity excuses an undefended piece or delayed king safety.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 013 Decode: Closed Spanish family

Prompt: Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job?

Recall: Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

LESSON 014 Play: Closed Spanish family

Prompt: Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job?

Recall: Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

LESSON 015 Decode: Berlin family

Prompt: Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay?

Recall: The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

LESSON 016 Play: Berlin family

Prompt: Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay?

Recall: The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

LESSON 017 Decode: Open Spanish family

Prompt: Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move?

Recall: In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

LESSON 018 Play: Open Spanish family

Prompt: Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move?

Recall: In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Closed Spanish family

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8

Decision: Which black piece has the least useful future, and what route gives it a central job?

Memory: Spanish retreats are investments: name the destination and the break they support.

CARD 2

Berlin family

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

Decision: Can Black activate quickly enough that the uncastled king becomes an asset rather than a delay?

Memory: The Berlin is an active endgame, not an early draw offer.

CARD 3

Open Spanish family

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5

Decision: Which central pawn or knight is loose after White's next forcing move?

Memory: In the Open Spanish, activity is the compensation and must remain concrete.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
013 Decode: Closed Spanish family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
014 Play: Closed Spanish family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
015 Decode: Berlin family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
016 Play: Berlin family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
017 Decode: Open Spanish family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
018 Play: Open Spanish family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.